

STATE Counts

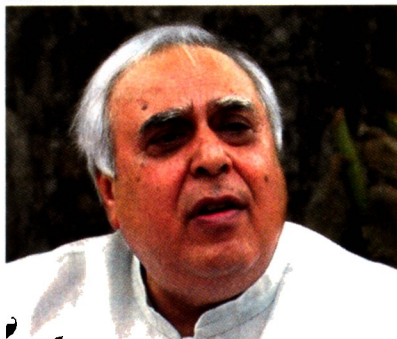
- 1 **Karnataka offers free education till Class X. But the RTE Act is different because it gives the child a fundamental right to demand education. The current teacher student ratio is 1:25 which means only the physical infrastructure needs to be ramped up. The state will need to spend Rs 1,300 crore over the next five years.**
- 2 **Gujarat passed the Compulsory Primary Education Act in 1961 but it was never notified and thus remained only on paper. The state and the Centre will have to spend Rs 2,500 crore on salaries and another Rs 1,000 crore on building 30,000 new school rooms. The state Government will have to recruit 60,000 new teachers. In Gujarat, elementary education ends at Class VII, but the RTE provides for free education till Class VIII.**
- 3 **In Kerala, education up to Class XII is free, universal and compulsory since 1957. The minimum age of entry is five, not six as stipulated by the RTE Act. So next year, there will be no child in Class I, as every six-year-old will have gone to Class II by then.**
- 4 **Rajasthan requires Rs 1,758 crore to build 43,510 rooms in primary and upper primary schools, provide electricity in 57,032 schools, construct boundary walls in 33,500, girls' toilets in 2,881 and provide drinking water in 965 schools. It needs 13,000 new teachers at a cost of Rs 140 crore.**
- 5 **West Bengal now has free education in government schools only till Class IV.**

2005, it reached its most serious point when Sibal headed the sub-committee of the Central Advisory Board of Education, constituted to debate the provisions of the model Right to Education Bill. It is a law that will inevitably raise new conflicts as it unfolds, but it has been almost universally embraced except for an extreme group of conspiracy theorists who see this as an extension of the Government selling out to the West. For, it is difficult to argue with its noble intention of allowing children of mixed backgrounds to study together or even of ensuring that the

omponent process. It also requires that though it applies to only those between six and 14, it will allow the children to continue in the system once they are introduced to it. In any case, the Centre is simultaneously working on the Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan with the aim of achieving universal access and quality secondary education, but if the experience of the SSA is anything to go by, the focus will be on quantity, not quality.

The most important effect of the Act will be to bring about some measure of accountability in education, which is on the Concurrent List

SUMET INDER



“Education is a collaborative enterprise. When a child goes to school, there are several stakeholders involved in it.”

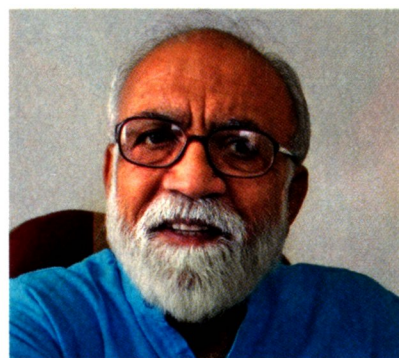
KAPIL SIBAL
Union Minister for HRD

obligation of providing education to a child belongs to the State, not to the parents or the child.

It is easy to get bogged down in the apparent problems. Take money. The RTE Act requires a spend of Rs 2,04,000 crore over the next five years though much of it is earmarked for seven states—Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. It requires hiring of nearly 13 lakh teachers to fill existing vacancies and fulfill the 1:30 ratio. It demands that private schools shed their reluctance to participate in the devel-

“The State is abdicating its Constitutional obligation of providing free and compulsory education of equitable quality to all.”

ANIL SADGOPAL
Professor, Delhi University



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and usually subservient to the politics between the states and the Centre. Yes, some states will drag their feet, whether it is Mayawati's Uttar Pradesh or the LDF's Kerala. If statue-struck Uttar Pradesh cites a lack of resources—after all, it is required to spend the most—then in Kerala the problem is the entry age which is five while the RTE Act has fixed it at six. “The new law in its present form may bring total chaos in the state's education sector, at least, in the beginning,” says Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan.

But as R. Govinda, vice-chancellor